

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

ALL TALK, NO PURGE

Rahul Gandhi has once again donned his reformist hat, this time in Gujarat, vowing to purge the local Congress of its "BJP sympathisers". Bold words, but whether Gujarat will actually see the sacking of the 20-odd delinquents, only time will tell. Rahul might also want to spend some time on Assam where party MLAs could offer a masterclass in political moonlighting, openly cosying up to the BJP. Since 2021, Shashikanta Das (Raha), Basanta Das (Mangoldoi), Kamalakhya Dey Purkayastha (Karimganj North) and Siddeque Ahmed (Karimganj South) have, at different points, publicly pledged their admiration for the Himanta Biswa Sarma-led BJP government. The last two even campaigned for the BJP in the Lok Sabha polls. The Congress high command's response? Suspension and petitions to the courts and the assembly speaker. Predictably, these have led nowhere—none of the leaders has been expelled so far.

Loaded Silence



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Samajwadi Party chief **Akhilesh Yadav** is facing flak now for, of all things, "his silence". The SP chief was abroad when former close aide and socialist writer Manoj Yadav a.k.a. Frank Huzur died on March 6. He returned to Lucknow before Holi but did not visit Huzur's family or issue a statement. Inside the party, whispers grew: should the leadership acknowledge Huzur? On social media, SP supporters were seen lamenting that even Yadav loyalists are now a forgotten lot. Ironically, during the last SP government (2012-17), Huzur's *Socialist Factor* magazine was seen as the party's unofficial voice; the man even enjoyed government accommodation. After the 2017 defeat, though, they fell out, and Huzur drifted to the Congress. In the end, it was left to Rahul Gandhi to send a condolence letter to the family.

BACKING DMK



Days after a spat with the AIADMK over a broken promise of a Rajya Sabha seat, Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) leader and widow of the late 'Karuppu MGR' Vijayakanth, **Premalatha**, appears to be eyeing a place in the DMK. On March 16, she backed the DMK government on the delimitation issue and welcomed the state budget for 2025-26. She even defended the DMK in the alleged TASMAC liquor scam, urging critics to show proof before making accusations. Is a pivot towards CM M.K. Stalin's Secular Progressive Alliance on ahead of the 2026 Tamil Nadu election?

Work from 'Farmhouse', Anyone?

Telangana's feisty chief minister **A. Revanth Reddy** never misses a chance to corner arch-rival K. Chandrashekar Rao, Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) supremo and his predecessor. On March 14, Revanth revealed that KCR, despite drawing Rs 57,84,124 as his MLA salary over 15 months, showed up in the assembly for just two days. Quoting the Supreme Court's definition of legislators as state employees, Revanth asked if KCR was following a new "work from farmhouse" model, long after the "work from home" practice ended. KCR, notorious for skipping the secretariat during his nearly decade-long stint as CM, might be slow to respond but, if the past is any indication, a counter-attack is merely a matter of time.



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BOLLYWOOD EYES THE N-E



Bollywood is once again training its lens on the scenic hills of Darjeeling and Sikkim. This is good news for both Gorkhaland Territorial Administration (GTA) chief Anit Thapa and Sikkim CM Prem Singh Tamang, as their respective regions are coming out of a period of instability—strikes and flash floods being the culprits. Director **Anurag Basu** is one of the first to return for his upcoming film starring Kartik Aaryan and Sreeleela. The region has long been part of Bollywood's storybook—from *Barsaat* (1949) and *Aradhana* (1969) to Basu's own *Barfi!* (2012) and *Jagga Jasoos* (2017).

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Avaneesh Mishra and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar